

Raising Teenage Boys - Printable Cards and Checklists

From *Raising Teenage Boys* by Claire Donnelly (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

Conversation Starters - The Card for the Car

None of these are about feelings, which is why they work. Side by side beats face to face.

Openers that get more than three words

What's the best thing you've seen on your phone this week?
Who's the worst teacher, and why specifically?
If you ran that school for a week, what would you change first?
What's actually going on with [friend]?
What's the game about? Properly - explain it to me.
What do people at school think about [thing in the news]?
What would happen if someone got caught vaping at your school?
What's the stupidest rule they have?

The harder subjects, asked sideways

Does anyone you know vape? What do they say about it?
What would you do if you were at a party and someone was really out of it?
If you needed to leave somewhere and couldn't say why, how could I get you out?
Have you ever seen someone get a lift off someone who'd been drinking?
What do people say about [online figure]? What's right about it?

Worth saying, not asking

The lift offer stands. Any time, anywhere, no questions that night. I mean it.
You can tell me something bad and I won't go off at you.
I'm not going to pretend I know what it's like. But I'm not shockable.
I was wrong about that.
I like you. Not just love - like.

The rules for receiving an answer

1. Keep your face still, whatever he says.
2. Make a noise, not a statement. "Hm." "Right." "God."
3. Do not solve it. Ask what he reckons he'll do.
4. Never use it later as evidence.

The Screen and Phone Agreement

Fill this in **together**. The version he helps write is the one he keeps.

	Agreed
Phones out of bedrooms overnight, from	
Where phones charge overnight	
Phone-free times (meals, etc.) - applies to everyone	
School-night finish time for gaming	
Weekend arrangement	
How we handle "finish the match"	
What happens if the agreement is broken	
When we review this again	

Parents sign too. A rule the adults break is not a rule.

Signed - him	Signed - us	Date

The questions that actually matter

Not how many hours, but: Is he sleeping? Is he still doing anything else? Is he seeing friends in person? Is school holding up? What happens when it's taken away? Is it a retreat from something?

The Risk Conversation Checklist

Tick these off over months, not in one sitting. Short, factual, repeated, in the car.

Cars - the highest-value items in the book

	Done
The no-questions lift: any time, anywhere, no discussion that night - and honoured the first time it's inconvenient	
Passenger limits in the first year of driving	
No night driving early on	
Supervised practice well beyond the legal minimum	
Phone physically out of reach while driving	
Never get in a car with a driver who has been drinking or using - and how to get out of it without losing face	

Alcohol and drugs

	Done
Units and strength, concretely - not abstract moderation	
What to do if a friend is unconscious: recovery position, ambulance, stay, nobody gets in trouble for calling	
Being drunk is never an excuse for what he does to someone else	
Cannabis: stronger than it was, higher risk early and heavy, the psychosis link where there's family history	
Vaping and nicotine dependence	
Anything bought from someone he doesn't know may not be what it's said to be	

And the agreed exit

Our code word or message, so he can ask to be collected	

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without saying why in front of anyone	
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Warning Signs - Ordinary, or a Signal?

The question is not how moody he is. It is **whether he has pulled away from everything, or only from you.**

Ordinary adolescence	Worth acting on
Variable - grim Tuesday, fine Saturday	Persistent, most days, two weeks or more
Grim at home, fine with friends	Withdrawn in every setting
Monosyllabic, but still eats with you and takes lifts	Stopped eating with the family, door shut for days
Still enjoys at least one thing	No pleasure in anything he used to love
Irritable in patches	Irritability that has become constant
Normal tiredness	Marked change in sleep, appetite or weight

In boys, depression most often looks like irritability, anger and withdrawal - not sadness. Waiting for him to look sad is the commonest reason it gets missed.

Today, not next week

Any mention of suicide or not wanting to be here - including as a joke, or in a message you weren't meant to see	

Self-harm of any kind	
Violence that has injured someone	
Signs of exploitation - unexplained money, a second phone, older "friends", going missing	
Unsafe intoxication	

Ask directly if you are worried: "Have you ever thought about killing yourself?" Asking does not plant the idea. Not asking is how it stays unknown.

In the United States: 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, call or text, any hour - by him or by you.

While things are difficult, reduce access to means - medicines including ordinary painkillers in quantity, and any firearms, stored separately or out of the house. One of the best-evidenced things a parent can do.

When to Get Help - The Appointment Sheet

Take this with you.

What I have seen, with dates

Date	What I noticed

How long it has been going on

What has changed (sleep / appetite / friends / school / interests / mood)

What to say

"I think he may be depressed, and I would like him assessed."
Ask what the waiting time is, and what to do meanwhile.
Ask whether he can be seen without me in the room.
Ask when to come back if nothing improves.

Go yourself if he won't come. That is normal and doctors expect it. **Go back** if nothing changes - being reassured once is not the end of it.

What to Hand Over, and Roughly When

Autonomy given is worth far more than autonomy taken. Review on his birthday and loosen something **before** he asks.

Age	Hand over	He should be failing at (cheaply)
11-13	Getting to school and locally; own washing; some cooking; money that's genuinely his to waste	Forgotten kit, spent it all on day one
14-15	Out with friends unsupervised; own schedule; booking his own appointments; casual work; being left in the house	Missed buses, late homework, running out of money
16-17	Travel further; late nights with an agreed plan; all his own money; his own academic decisions; learning to drive	Consequences at school that are his, not yours
17-18	Essentially adult arrangements, with ordinary household courtesy	Most things - while you're still there

Rescue for: health, safety, anything permanent. **Do not rescue for:** inconvenience.

What never gets handed over: warmth, interest, and the standing offer of a lift at three in the morning.